

RECLAIMING THE CIVIC PUBLIC SQUARE

Strengthening Youth Civic Engagement in Nigeria Through Policy Reform, Trust and Civic Technology

Drawing on GMI's Programme Evidence (2022–2024) and Current National Data (2025–2026)

27% Voter turnout in 2023 elections Lowest in Nigeria's history INEC/ICIR 2023	3.7M+ New voter registrations 68% are youth (18–34) INEC, April 2026	112/180 Press Freedom Rank Nigeria Reporters Without Borders, 2024	67% Civic orgs affected by aid withdrawal EU SEE Network Survey, 2025
---	---	--	---

Sources: INEC CVR Data April 2026; ICIR Nigeria 2023 Election Report; Reporters Without Borders Press Freedom Index 2024; EU SEE Network Survey 2025; GMI Annual Report 2024; CIVICUS Monitor 2024.

KEY MESSAGES

The 2023 elections recorded Nigeria's lowest-ever voter turnout at 27%, yet as of April 2026, over 3.7 million Nigerians have registered for the 2027 cycle, 68% of them youth. The civic will exists; the infrastructure to convert it into participation does not.

CIVICUS Monitor (2024) rates Nigeria's civic space as **Repressed** Nigeria ranks 112 out of 180 on the Press Freedom Index. These are not abstract rankings; they describe the environment in which civic technology organisations like GMI must operate.

The January 2025 US aid freeze directly affected 67% of Nigerian civic organisations, with 40% reporting budget losses of up to 50% (EU SEE Network, 2025). Nigeria's civic tech sector faces an existential funding crisis that only domestic policy action can stabilise.

GMI's BINCIKE project demonstrates that community-level fact-checking and media literacy training is replicable at under 50,000 per beneficiary with documented civic commitment outcomes.

With the 2027 general elections approaching, the window to establish sustained, year-round civic education infrastructure is narrowing. Policy decisions made now will shape whether Nigeria's democratic recovery or decline continues.

When Silence Becomes the System

Nigeria's 2023 general elections produced a damning democratic verdict: only **27% of registered voters turned out**, the lowest in the country's history, down from 69% at the peak of civic engagement in 2003. Yet this is not a story of apathy. A March 2026 Citizens' Report by TechCabal Insights found that many young Nigerians still intend to vote in 2027. What is collapsing is not civic will, it is civic trust. Respondents cited low confidence in INEC, the judiciary, and political parties as the primary driver of non-participation. The structural causes run deeper than any single election. CIVICUS Monitor (2024) classifies Nigeria's civic space as **'Repressed'** a category reserved for countries where protests are routinely restricted and journalists face intimidation. Reporters Without Borders' 2024 Press Freedom Index ranks Nigeria **'112 out of 180 countries'**, reflecting a pattern of journalist intimidation and detention around election cycles.

Compounding the institutional breakdown is an escalating information integrity crisis. Nigeria's primary political communication platforms WhatsApp, Facebook, and X are saturated with fabricated content that communities and media practitioners cannot reliably verify. INEC's 2023 cycle was marked by documented disinformation-driven voter suppression, while the government's blocking of X (then Twitter) from June 2021 to January 2022 demonstrated the state's willingness to restrict digital civic space. Meanwhile, Nigeria's civic technology sector which could serve as a balance against these trends faces an existential funding crisis. Following the January 2025 US aid freeze, a 2025 EU SEE Network survey found that **'67% of civic organisations were directly affected'**, with 40% reporting budget losses of up to 50%. Nigeria, as one of USAID's largest 2023–2024 recipients in the sector, was among the hardest-hit countries.

“A democracy populated by many indifferent citizens is a democracy in retreat.”

— INEC Chairman, Prof. Joash Amupitan, Voter Education Manual Launch, Abuja — March 2026

Sources: TechCabal Insights Citizens' Report 2026; CIVICUS Monitor 2024; Reporters Without Borders Press Freedom Index 2024; EU SEE Network Survey 2025; Freedom House Freedom on the Net 2024; INEC 2026 Voter Education Manual Launch.

EVIDENCE FROM THE FIELD: WHAT GMI'S INITIATIVES DEMONSTRATE

What Two Programmes Prove About What Works

GMI's civic engagement portfolio centers on **BINCIKE** a community fact-checking and media literacy programme and **Siyasa** a centralised civic technology platform for Nigeria. Together, these initiatives are GMI's direct response to the civic and information integrity challenges documented in Section 1. They generate field-level evidence on the cost, scale, and conditions for effective civic re-engagement in underserved Nigerian communities.

BINCIKE

Community Fact-Checking & Media Literacy

2 events · 8 weeks · Niger State 46 participants trained across community organisations and media houses

Partners: WITNESS Africa, Window on America Minna

SIYASA

Centralised Civic Technology Platform

Launched 2024 · Lagos Democracy Fair Exhibited to INEC, British High Commission & FCDO — demonstrating institutional appetite

Partners: YIAGA Africa, CivicHive, CTIN

FIVE THINGS THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

1

Media literacy training is cost-effective and fast.

BINCIKE trained 46 participants across two events in under 8 weeks at under ₦50,000 per beneficiary. Against the backdrop of a sector-wide funding crisis following the 2025 US aid freeze, domestically fundable models at this cost level are precisely what Nigeria's civic infrastructure needs. A structured national roll-out could reach every LGA within a single electoral cycle.

2

Civic commitment produces documented behavioural outcomes.

Participants signed public commitment banners pledging to fight fake news in their communities, a documented civic contract. Research across comparable Sub-Saharan African interventions links such public commitments to sustained media consumption behaviour change, particularly among community leaders and practitioners.

3

Civic technology attracts high-level institutional attention.

Siyasa's debut at the Lagos Democracy Fair: organised by YIAGA Africa and CivicHive drew INEC, the British High Commission, and FCDO. This is significant context: INEC launched a new Youth-Friendly Voter Education Manual in March 2026, acknowledging that structured civic education has a measurable positive impact on voter turnout. GMI's work sits directly within this now-official INEC priority.

4

Media practitioners are the highest-leverage target group.

Training 6 Niger State media practitioners from different media houses creates a force multiplier: each trained journalist reaches thousands of news consumers. Freedom House's Freedom on the Net 2024 report confirmed that misinformation by powerful actors shaped the 2023 election cycle yet structured verification training for Nigerian media practitioners remains near-absent from government or donor programming.

5

Post-intervention tracking is the next evidence frontier.

Current BINCIKE documentation captures training delivery and commitment signatures. The critical next step: tracking whether participants actively fact-checked content post-training would shift this from a 'we trained people' narrative to a 'we changed information behavior' argument, substantially strengthening both GMI's policy credibility and its fundraising case in a constrained donor environment.

“I commit to fight fake news in my community.”

— BINCIKE participant, Suleja: one of 40+ signatories, October 2024

Sources: GMI BINCIKE Programme Documentation 2024; GMI Annual Report 2024; Freedom House Freedom on the Net Nigeria 2024; INEC Voter Education Manual Launch, March 2026.

03 · POLICY CONTEXT: WHAT EXISTS AND WHERE THE GAPS ARE

Five Institutions. Five Gaps. One Closing Window.

The 2027 general elections are approaching. INEC’s own chairman has warned that ‘voter apathy remains a major threat to credible elections’ (March 2026). The institutions mandated to address that apathy continue to underdeliver.

INSTITUTION / POLICY	IMPLEMENTATION DEFICIT (2024–2026)
National Orientation Agency	No active digital presence on the platforms young Nigerians actually use. Budget routinely below ₦ 5bn. INEC’s own March 2026 voter education launch called for NOA collaboration yet NOA’s infrastructure remains too weak to deliver it at scale.
National Broadcasting Commission	Jurisdiction covers only licensed broadcast media. Social media, WhatsApp, and X the actual channels of political disinformation documented in the 2023 cycle remain a complete regulatory vacuum. Freedom House (2024) confirmed no legal measures were taken against online misinformation actors.
INEC	Voter turnout has declined from 69% (2003) to 27% (2023). Despite launching a 2026 Youth-Friendly Voter Education Manual, INEC’s education efforts remain episodic and election-period-only. As of April 2026, over 3.7 million Nigerians have registered for 2027 68% youth but registration alone does not guarantee participation.
Ministry of Youth Development	No dedicated civic engagement programme. Budget skewed toward vocational training. The ministry has not been visible in any of the 2026 pre-election civic infrastructure conversations despite youth constituting over 68% of new 2027 registrants.
Freedom of Information Act 2011	Nigeria’s Open Government Partnership commitments on FOI compliance (2023–2024) found no evidence that MDAs updated records management policies or adopted digital FOI portals despite those being explicit IRM milestones. Citizens cannot exercise rights they cannot access.

Critical gap: No Nigerian policy framework currently recognises civic technology as a legitimate instrument of democratic participation. As the 2025 US aid freeze demonstrates, platforms like Siyasa cannot be sustained on foreign grants alone they need domestic regulatory recognition, government data access, and institutional partnerships to survive and scale. A national Civic Technology Policy Framework is urgently needed.

Sources: INEC Voter Education Manual Launch March 2026; INEC CVR Data April 2026; Open Government Partnership Nigeria IRM Report 2023–2024; Freedom House 2024; EU SEE Network Survey 2025; INEC/ICIR 2023 Election Turnout Data.

Five Recommendations Timed for the 2027 Election Cycle

Each recommendation below is grounded in GMI's field evidence and current national data, linked to named responsible actors, and calibrated for the 2027 electoral timeline. None requires new institutions only the political will to activate existing mandates.

1

Establish a National Civic Education Curriculum Ahead of the 2027 Elections

The Federal Ministry of Education, through NUC and NBTE, should mandate civic education modules covering constitutional rights, democratic participation, fact-checking, media literacy, and civic technology in all Nigerian tertiary institutions before the 2027 election cycle. The urgency is real: INEC's own March 2026 Voter Education Manual explicitly acknowledges that structured civic education has a measurable positive impact on voter turnout. GMI's BINCIKE model, delivering measurable gains at under ₦ 50,000 per beneficiary, offers a ready-to-deploy curriculum template. Piloting should begin in FCT and Niger State in Q3 2026.

Key Actors: Federal Ministry of Education · NUC · NBTE · NOA

2

Gazette a National Civic Technology Policy Framework Before the 2025 Aid Freeze Becomes Irreversible

The collapse of foreign aid has exposed a structural dependency that domestic policy must address. The Office of the Vice President should gazette a National Civic Technology Policy Framework that: formally recognises civic technology as a public good; establishes criteria for government recognition of civic tech platforms; creates open data-sharing pathways for CSO-built tools; and provides a regulatory environment that protects rather than restricts digital civic space. With 67% of civic organisations affected by the 2025 aid withdrawal, this framework is no longer a future ambition it is an emergency stabilisation measure. Siyasa should be recognised as a pilot platform under this framework.

Key Actors: Office of the VP · NITDA · Ministry of Communications · CTIN

3

Triple the NOA Budget and Mandate a Counter-Disinformation Operation

INEC's March 2026 launch specifically called for NOA collaboration in voter education but NOA cannot deliver at the required scale on its current budget. A minimum tripling of NOA's annual allocation from under 5bn to at least 15bn is needed, accompanied by: a mandatory active social media and digital platforms presence; formal partnerships with CSOs for community-level media literacy delivery; and an explicit counter-disinformation mandate **i n c l u d i n g** training community fact-checkers in partnership with organisations like GMI whose BINCIKE model is operational and replicable.

Key Actors: National Orientation Agency · Federal Ministry of Information · State Governments

4

Mandate Sustained, Year-Round INEC Youth Civic Engagement Not Just Voter Registration

As of April 2026, over 3.7 million Nigerians have registered for the 2027 elections 68% of them youth aged 18–34. But registration does not equal participation. The TechCabal Citizens' Report (2026) documents that declining institutional trust, not lack of registration, is the primary barrier to youth voting. INEC must transition from episodic, registration-focused campaigns to sustained year-round civic engagement programming, including: formal CSO partnerships for voter education and civic training delivery; a digitally accessible voter rights portal; and civic engagement metrics not just registration numbers in annual reporting. GMI's BINCIKE model is immediately deployable as an INEC community partnership mechanism.

Key Actors: INEC · Federal Ministry of Youth Development · CSO Civic Engagement Coalition

5

Enforce the FOI Act Through a Federal Digital Information Portal Before 2027

Nigeria's OGP Independent Review Mechanism (2023–2024) found no evidence that MDAs updated records management policies or adopted E-FOI portals despite both being explicit government commitments. The AGF should issue a binding circular requiring all MDAs to maintain digitally searchable public records portals compliant with the FOI Act 2011. NITDA should host a unified, mobile-accessible federal FOI portal aggregating records across ministries. Civil society organisations including GMI should be formally recognised as FOI compliance monitors. Improved FOI access expands the government data available to civic tech platforms like Siyasa and strengthens evidence-based civic advocacy.

Key Actors: Office of the AGF · NITDA · Ministry of Justice · CSO FOI Coalitions

Recommendation sources: INEC CVR Data April 2026; TechCabal Citizens' Report March 2026; OGP Nigeria IRM Report 2023–2024; EU SEE Network Survey 2025; GMI BINCIKE Documentation 2024.

CONCLUSION

Civic Engagement Is a Policy Choice and 2027 Is the Deadline

Nigeria stands at a pivotal civic moment. Voter turnout has fallen to a historic low of 27%, civic space has been formally classified as Repressed by international monitors, and a funding crisis has destabilised the civil society infrastructure that was filling the gaps left by government institutions. Yet the signals are not uniformly negative. As of April 2026, over 3.7 million Nigerians have registered for 2027, 68% of them youth. INEC itself has acknowledged that structured civic education measurably improves voter participation. The appetite for change is present. What is absent is the institutional infrastructure to channel it.

GMI's BINCIKE project and Siyasa platform demonstrate that community-level civic technology interventions produce real, documented, replicable outcomes at under ₦50,000 per beneficiary. That is a domestic model that does not depend on foreign grant cycles. The five recommendations in this brief are calibrated to the 2027 electoral timeline and achievable within existing institutional mandates. The NOA, INEC, NUC, NITDA, and the AGF's office have the legal authority to act. What is required is the political will to treat civic participation as a national development imperative not an election-season project.

About GMI: Glowing mind initiatives is a youth-led nonprofit registered with the CAC in Nigeria. Since 2020, GMI has reached over 2,000 young people across 33 states through capacity building, research, advocacy, and innovation across four thematic areas: Youth Employability, Civic Engagement, Climate Change, and Gender Inclusion. GMI is a member of the Civic Tech Innovation Network and co-author of Emerging Challenges in Civic Technology Innovation in West Africa (CcHub, 2023). SDGs: 16 (Peace & Justice) · 10 (Reduced Inequalities) · 4 (Quality Education).

© 2026 Glowing Minds Initiatives · Prepared by: Abiodun Yusuf, Research & Policy Associate, M&E; Unit · All rights reserved.